

Install experience

Installing PC-BSD from that round platter is a no-brainer. But, of course, you can't really live without a brain. But then again...

1. Here we go. After you insert that platter and re-boot (no, not throw a boot, throw them at politicians) your PC, a text screen shows up. Scary as it may seem, hit 8 and press *Enter*. (Or just press *Enter*. You cannot use ZFS then.) Hit *n* when it asks you if you want to check the integrity of the installer images.
2. Up comes the first installer screen! Leave the keypad and language settings alone, but change the timezone to Asia/Calcutta (that's the only IST zone present). Hit *Next*.
3. Agree to the licence if you want to go ahead. There's a lot of proprietary cruft in there, though.
4. In this screen, leave all the settings as they are: New Install, Desktop Version, and CD/DVD source. Hit *Next*.
5. Here, fill out your user profile details. After you're done with the text entry, change the shell to `/PCBSD/local/bin/bash`. That's the only way to survive. Hit *Add*, check the auto-login details and hit *Next*.
6. Here you get to choose your hard disk details. Choose a hard disk in the first selection box, then a partition on the second, or just select "Use Entire Disk". If you have less than 1GB of RAM, ZFS won't work (it just won't show up). Here, UFS+SU is the best choice. Review your choices, and hit *Next*.
7. In this screen, you get to choose optional components. At a bare minimum, you need Firefox, because Konqueror (included as default) is not good enough. Choose Amarok if you must, or stick with the included JuK. Hit *Next*.
8. After a bogus *Ready To Install* screen where you just hit *Next*, everything is installed.
9. After the first boot, a small applet comes up asking for videocard details. Choose as per your own hardware, and then, you're done! As simple as 1-2-3! Um... add 5,6,7,8 and 9 there :~)

entire KDE 4.2.2 application set. At installation time, you will notice that a lot of stuff like OpenOffice.org, Firefox and Amarok were optional. I did install all of them. Amarok and OOo versions come up as shockers: 1.4 and 2.4, respectively. Everything else is fine. And the moment it booted up (it was five days from the release date), an update for each and every optional package was available. A 500MB download, all in all. OOo 3.0.1, Amarok 2.2, what else? Those guys could have populated the DVD with those instead of legacy versions.

Take it for a ride

I did that for starters. There were no disappointments, save some hiccups. The first thing I did was remove the normal launcher and enable Lancelot. An annoying problem was that while log-out works, hovering the mouse on 'Switch

Users' brings me a configure GDM menu item.

I next tested out the bundled version of Wine 1.1. I browsed away with Dolphin and double-clicked on the installation file of Foobar2000, a free (not *libre*) music player for Windows. It installed fine, but would just not play any audio. WinCg didn't help, and running Wine from Konsole resulted in a segfault. Bye, bye, Wine! By the way, it's supposed to run Linux binaries natively, but I didn't check.

Broadband connections in Bridged Mode (that is, the dial-up-like mode) would not work, so I ended up hacking my modem and setting it to 'always-on' mode. Now the Internet rocks! It's fast, and it's quite stable.

Speaking of speed and stability, PC-BSD is by far the most responsive system ever to run on my PC. It's stable as well. Save for the Wine segfaults, nothing has gone wrong yet. 3D effects are enabled by default and they rock. MP3s play by default, as do H.264 video. By the way, PC-BSD is not for FOSS purists, because starting with the BSD licence itself (which makes it 'almost public domain', save reserving a copyright), it includes all sorts of encumbered drivers such as NVIDIA's, and codecs such as MP3 and H.264. By the way, Flash is included as well.

The nitty gritty

PC-BSD wouldn't install on logical drives, but the BSD people say that it should install on an extended partition, preferring their own slices and disk labels rather than Windows's L.D.s. Coming to partitioning, I must share my installation choices with you. I booted up the installer with option 8, or with support for Sun's Zetabyte File System (ZFS). I selected this in the partitioning screen, and the installer barked at me: "ZFS is for 64-bit systems with more than 4 GB of RAM." I have two. Who cares about warnings? I ignored it and, ooh la la! ZFS is literally a rocket at managing the storage of my files!

PC-BSD is geared towards newbies, but when they see the black screen with three lines of text after starting their PC (the boot-loader), they may faint. If they don't, after pressing the desired F-key for FreeBSD (yes, it's not PC-BSD), they'll come to a screen with pretty nice choices that are also baffling. So what should they do? Just hit *Enter*, guys—the default choice is fine. After that, don't try to make any sense of those meaningless lines of text flashing by. And don't enter your login name when prompted; leave it as it is. KDE will start automatically.

Just how easy is it to crash this stuff?

It's actually very easy to crash it, but it takes a while to figure that out. Actually, I did it accidentally. I was just casually browsing the directory tree, and chanced upon a boot-splash image. I knew there must be a way of enabling it. Turned out there was: four commented lines in `/boot/loader.conf`. I uncommented that stuff and rebooted the PC. That was the last time I saw the desktop.